Diplomatic exchanges between Myanmar and the West—and especially Myanmar's scrapping of the Myitsone dam—prompted China to start searching for new ways to salvage the relationship. In 2012, academic-style journals in China ran several articles analysing what went wrong with Beijing's Myanmar policy and what should be done to rectify it. One proposed measure has been to launch a public relations campaign in Myanmar aimed at overhauling China's current negative image in the country and to extend promises of help with the government's peace process. Many countries support this process financially and a host of Western NGOs are involved as advisers to the government's peace committee—but only China can wield a carrot as well as a stick: aid, loans, and trade and guns to the UWSA.

China cannot give up its newly-won access to the Indian Ocean and Myanmar's strategic importance to Beijing cannot, therefore, be overestimated. More than 60 per cent of the world's oil shipments pass through the Indian Ocean, from the Middle East's oil fields to China, Japan, and other strong economies in the region, as does 70 per cent of all container traffic to and from the Asian industrial countries and the rest of the world. While traffic across the Atlantic has diminished and that across the Pacific is static, trade across the Indian Ocean is increasing. Parts of the ocean, especially in the west around the Horn of Africa and next to the Strait of Malacca in the east, are areas where pirates are active and terrorists have been shipping arms to various conflict zones in the region, which has prompted tighter regional co-operation. But there are more fundamental, geopolitical, threats to stability in the Indian Ocean. Not only the United States but also Japan and India distrust China. For India, it began with the border conflicts which culminated in the 1962 War and Japan has for decades been involved in a dispute with China on the ownership of a group of islands in the East China Sea, called Senkaku in Japanese and Diaoyutai in Chinese.

With two nationalists now as prime ministers of their respective countries, Shinzo Abe of Japan since December 2012 and Narendra Modi of India since May 2014, the battle lines and alliances have become clearer. Although regional naval co-operation actually began in 2007 with annual joint exercises, called Exercise Malabar, by India, Japan, Australia, Singapore, and the United States, they were initially held with relatively informal arrangements in the sea off Japan. But, in 2015, Exercise Malabar